

spreads, and consumer confidence surveys—change so much from month to month and quarter to quarter that they become useless more than a few quarters out.

It's hard to believe, but in 2025, we are *still* dealing with the fallout from the GFC of 2007–09. That *Wall Street Journal* article warned that in 2016, the expansion has “continued for 88 months, making it the fourth-longest period of growth in records stretching to 1854.” Had you paid heed to those recession warnings, you would have missed another eight years of robust GDP expansion and ongoing new market highs. That includes the 34% sell-off into the start of Covid, and a weak 2022 that saw equities fall about 20%.

The economy doesn't just get old and die; something fundamental must occur to halt progress.

Media types love to toss around the word “unprecedented,” but unprecedented things happen all the time. In 2020, there were 32 new highs in the market. *Unprecedented!* A global pandemic? *Unprecedented!* As Bridgewater founder Ray Dalio points out, “unprecedented usually means you haven't seen it in your lifetime, but it very likely has happened before.” Records get broken all the time.

Forecasts of a recession arriving during the next four years are just a waste of print and pixels. The only thing these predictions do accomplish is to remind us that yes, there is always a storm somewhere off in the future. But you can never tell very far in advance when it will strike.



A risk of relying on modeled data is that we can too easily forget how things like money are supposed to work. We tackle one of the most deceptive data crimes involving cash in our next chapter.

¹⁵³ Josh Zumbrun, “Economists Believe a Recession Is Likely Within Next Four Years,” *The Wall Street Journal* (October 13, 2016).

¹⁵⁴ Subsequent revisions made only one of the quarters negative.